ART OF LIVING BEAUTIFULLY

From worldly finds to striking accents, discover how curated and carefully handpicked decor can elevate your home for the festive season

By SAMIR WADEKAR

Sometimes a designer is essentially doing theatrical work, which is giving a new space an inherited story and a past. The pieces of furniture, artworks, textiles and objects become poetic devices through which a story unfolds. For this festive *mise-en-scène* of a living room and dining table, I carefully gathered a variety of objects from Nilaya Anthology in Mumbai. When I first imagined this festive setting, I wanted to create spaces that felt as inviting as they were comforting. Drawing from the store's collection, I brought the living room and dining area to life with a distinctly maximalist spirit.

Textiles and fabrics play a generous role in this composition while bringing a festive spirit; the graphic print on the sofa by Pavitra Rajaram Design, a handwoven Ikat fabric from central Asia (which is draped over the console), a framed Nathdwara Pichwai depicting the Rasa Lila and a lustrous Mashru silk table cloth boldly brimming with joy and colour. Though I used a contemporary centre table by Glas Italia and the iconic Utrecht chair by Cassina in the living room, indigenous and vintage objects migrate throughout the space. A framed Tholu Bommalata puppet brings a sense of whimsy, while candles, butter lamps and coloured pieces add to the festive cheer. Each work has a distinct story to reveal and each artist comes from an even more distinct history. Pairing such diverse works and mediums reveals the stories of our subcontinent.

No festivity is truly complete without a memorable meal. Being a maximalist at heart, I wanted the dining table to be a little wilder, more playful and deliberately unpredictable. The wildness of the table was brought to life by floral arrangements crafted by Tanish Malji, while two framed lithographs depicting a noble couple (placed opposite each other) introduce an element of whimsy. They almost become surprise guests at the table, inviting curiosity and conversation. The exuberant colours of the florals, paired with handmade tableware from Egypt, heighten the celebratory mood. Handmade ceramics by Jacqueline Leighton-Boyce and Dee Barnes further contribute to the table's spirited, eclectic character.



Photograph by ADITYA SINHA

Having closely worked with Pavitra Rajaram while building the language for the visual storytelling at Nilaya Anthology, I am convinced that craftsmanship rewards close looking. A small carved bowl can have enormous significance without having the scale to furnish a room.

Most importantly, I don't try to make every object look special. If everything is artisanal, nothing feels meaningful. Let the handmade pieces coexist with inexpensive, inherited, practical and especially whimsical objects. These give a festive space its soul.